

Keep your Smartsheet tracker current — *no code*

A no-programming companion that lets the **whole study team** — project management, data management, medical writers — keep a Smartsheet program tracker **current automatically**, using only **Smartsheet’s own Automation** and, for your email, **Outlook’s own Rules**. **No Power Automate**, no scripts, no SAS, no R — and **no PHI** on the sheet.

Two truths to start with — they shape everything here.

1. **Smartsheet keeps existing rows current by asking their owners.** A recurring *Request an update* emails each owner a one-click mini-form of just their cells; they Submit and it writes back to the row — in place, no duplicates, no login.
2. **Everything here is native.** Smartsheet’s own Automation handles updates, alerts, reminders, and the weekly digest; native **Smartsheet Forms** collect new items; **Outlook Rules** organize your study email. The one thing that genuinely needs code — updating a specific row *by key* automatically from your validated pipeline — is the **SAS/R SHEETLINK** in the **Biostatistician package**.

The 60-second version

1. **Smartsheet asks for the updates.** A recurring **Request an update** emails each row’s owner just their cells every Monday; they click *Open request*, fill them in, and Submit — it saves to the row. No one has to open the sheet.
2. **A form collects new items.** A native **Smartsheet form** adds a new row for each submission — clean intake of new tasks, issues, or requests, straight into the sheet.
3. **Smartsheet sends the weekly digest.** A recurring **Alert someone** (or a saved **Report** set to send on a schedule) emails the at-risk & overdue items every Friday — all inside Smartsheet.
4. **It alerts the right people.** When a Status turns *At Risk*, a Smartsheet **Alert someone** notifies the PM; native **reminders** fire before each due date. Configured once, editable by a PM, no code.

Which tool for which job?

Goal	Native way	Tool
Keep existing rows current	Recurring Request an update — owners refresh their own cells on a schedule.	Smartsheet Automation
Collect new items	A Smartsheet form → a new row.	Smartsheet Forms
Alerts, reminders, approvals	Alert someone / reminders / Request an approval .	Smartsheet Automation
Weekly roll-up / digest	A recurring Alert someone , or a saved Report sent on a schedule.	Smartsheet
Organize study email	Rules — move, categorize, flag (the Rules Wizard).	Outlook Rules
Update a row by key from a pipeline	Needs the API (code).	SAS/R SHEETLINK — Biostatistician package

See it [on screen, step by step](#) — then [build it yourself](#).

See it on screen — the no-code setup, click by click

No scripting, no add-on, no new vendor. Five screens in Smartsheet’s own Automation give you a tracker that keeps itself current. Here is exactly what each one looks like.

CP-101 Program Tracker

Grid view

PI

FileAutomationFormsInsertFilter

Share

	Task	Status	% Complete	Owner	Due
1	Enrollment vs plan	On Track	45%	MR M. Reyes	—
2	ADaM spec — finalize	On Track	60%	AP A. Patel	15 Jun
3	Database soft-lock / data cut	On Track	40%	AP A. Patel	17 Jun
4	Dry-run TLFs	Watch	10%	JK J. Kim	24 Jun
5	DSMB pack	At Risk	0%	B Biostat	30 Jun

1 · The tracker you already keep. Operational columns only — status, % complete, owner, due. Never participant-level data. The **Automation** menu sits right in the toolbar.

FileAutomationForms

+ Create from template...

Start from a pre-built workflow

Create from scratch...

Manage workflows

Request an update every week

Email each row's owner to update their own cells on a recurring schedule.

Alert someone when...

Notify a person when a value changes.

Record a date when...

Stamp a date column on a change.

2 · Automation ▶ Create from template. Smartsheet ships the exact one you want — “Request an update every week.”

Weekly status request

CancelSave

WHEN

When a date is reached

Trigger — runs the workflow on a schedule

Run

Frequency

At

Custom recurrence

Weekly · every Monday

8:00 AM (sheet owner's time zone)

+

THEN

Request an update

Action — email each owner a form for their row

Send to

Include fields

Owner (contact in row)

Status ✓

% Complete ✓

Next action ✓

Due ✓

Task ID

Owner

Notes

3 · The visual workflow builder — the whole setup. A **WHEN** trigger (“When a date is reached,” set to a weekly / Monday recurrence) flows into a **THEN** action (“Request an update,” sent to each row’s owner, including only Status, % Complete, Next action, Due). Then **Save**. That is the entire build.

Smartsheet Automation <automation@smartsheet.com>

CP-101 — please update your row

Hi A. Patel — your weekly update for **Database soft-lock / data cut** is ready. It takes ten seconds, and you don't need a Smartsheet login.

Open update form →

SMARTSHEET · UPDATE REQUEST

Database soft-lock / data cut

Status

On Track

% Complete

75%

Next action

Soft-lock complete; running data-cut QC

Due

19 Jun 2026

Submit update

Only your row's cells are shown · writes back in place

4 · **What each owner gets.** An email with **Open update form** (no Smartsheet login needed) → a form with *only their row's four cells* → **Submit**.

CP-101 Program Tracker Grid view

	Task	Status	% Complete	Owner	Due
1	Enrollment vs plan	On Track	45%	MR M. Reyes	—
2	ADaM spec — finalize	On Track	60%	AP A. Patel	15 Jun
3	Database soft-lock / data cut updated just now	On Track	75%	AP A. Patel	19 Jun
4	Dry-run TLFs	Watch	10%	JK J. Kim	24 Jun
5	DSMB pack	At Risk	0%	B Biostat	30 Jun

5 · **Written back in place.** Still five rows — the data-cut row moved to **75%** with its new date, updated in place. No duplicate, no copy-paste, no code, and nobody opened the sheet.

A faithful re-creation of the Smartsheet UI, built from Smartsheet's own help documentation — the menus, the visual workflow builder, and the update request are all real Smartsheet features. The full click-by-click instructions are in [Make the tracker update itself](#).

Two native engines — and an honest boundary

Nothing here is programming, and there's **no Power Automate**. **Smartsheet's own Automation** lives inside the sheet and does the heavy lifting; **Outlook's own Rules** organize your study email. Both are point-and-click features of tools you already have.

Sources of truth (operational)

row owners (on a schedule) · a native

Smartsheet form

· your

Outlook

inbox

↓ **keep rows current, alert, digest (Smartsheet)** · **organize email (Outlook)** ↓

Smartsheet Automation

recurring

Request an update

(in-place) ·

Alert someone

on change · reminders before a due date ·

Request an approval

· recurring digest

Outlook Rules

file / categorize / flag study email automatically (the Rules Wizard) so the right mail is organized — no Power Automate



The Smartsheet tracker

one current, shared view · owners refresh their rows on schedule · new items flow in via a form · alerts, reminders & the weekly digest already wired

Engine 1 — Smartsheet Automation (does almost everything)

Automation builds a workflow from a *trigger* + optional *condition* + *action*. The three that matter here: a **recurring Request an update** (owners edit *existing* rows, so the tracker stays current and never duplicates), a **recurring Alert someone** (the weekly digest and the at-risk page), and a native **Smartsheet Form** (adds new rows). All point-and-click.

Engine 2 — Outlook Rules (organize the email)

For email, Outlook's own **Rules Wizard** (*Rules* → *Manage Rules & Alerts* → *New Rule*) files study-ops mail into a folder, tags, or flags it automatically. The inbox gets organized; the *tracker* stays current through Smartsheet's update requests and form — no bridge tool between them.

The honest boundary. These native tools keep a tracker current, alert, remind, intake, and digest — all no-code. The one thing they can't do is **automatically update a specific existing row by key from your validated pipeline** (e.g., write last night's computed status into the matching row). That needs the Smartsheet API — which is exactly the **SAS/R SHEETLINK** in the Biostatistician package. For the team, owners keep their own rows current instead.

What the study team should automate

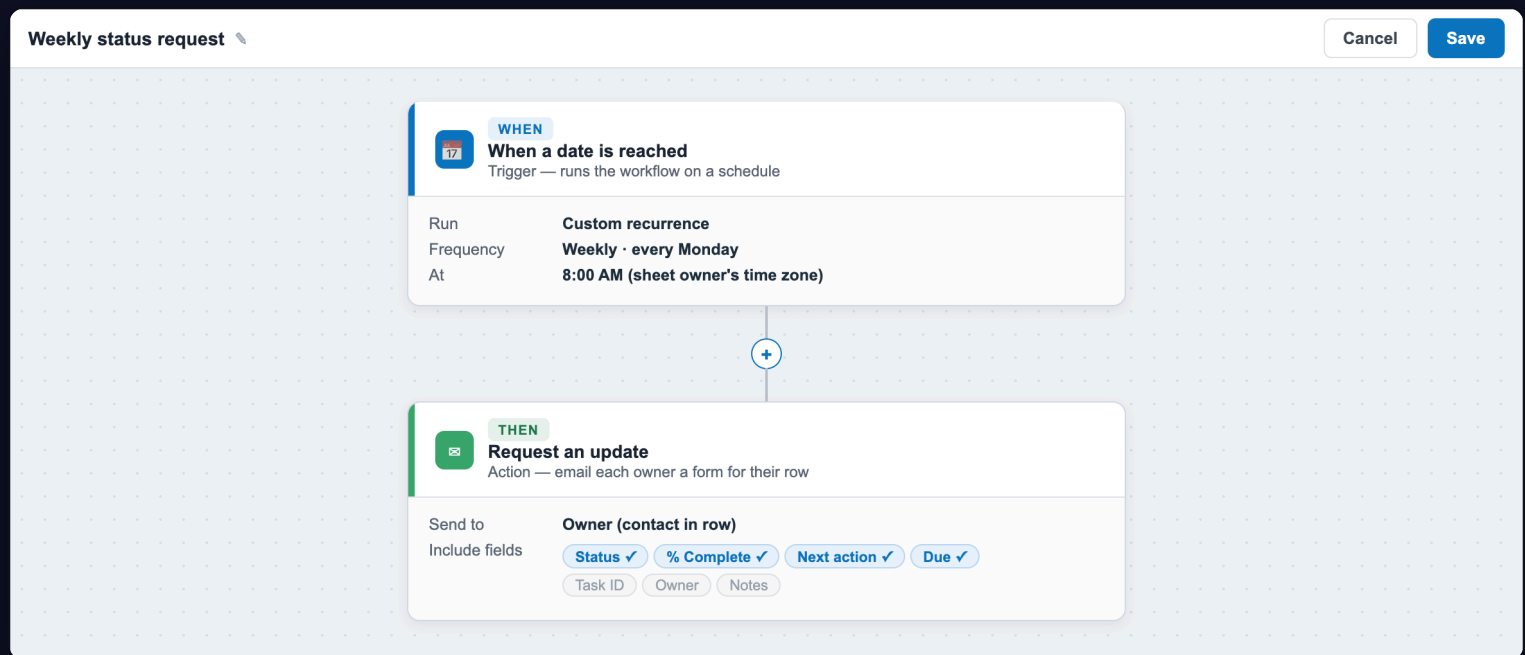
Everything here is **operational** — status, dates, counts, ownership. **None of it is participant-level or clinical.**

Use case	How (no code)	Who
Owners keep their own rows current	Smartsheet recurring Request an update — each owner gets emailed just their cells; they Submit and it writes back, in place.	PM sets up; whole team responds
New task / issue / request intake	A native Smartsheet form adds a new row per submission.	DM, CRAs, vendors submit
Due-date reminders	Smartsheet When a date is reached → Alert someone , e.g. 3 days before Due .	PM sets up once
At-risk alerts & escalation	Smartsheet When rows are changed → Alert someone / Request an approval .	PM sets up once
Weekly roll-up / digest	A recurring Alert someone , or a saved Report sent on a schedule — the at-risk & overdue items.	PM / medical writer
Organize study email	Outlook Rules — file, categorize, or flag study-ops mail automatically.	PM / study lead
Hand-offs & coverage	Smartsheet alert on an owner change → notify the new owner.	PM sets up once
Update rows by key from a validated pipeline	<i>Needs code/API</i> — the SAS/R SHEETLINK (Biostatistician package), not no-code.	Biostatistician

The split to remember: Smartsheet’s update requests *refresh existing rows* (no duplicates); a Smartsheet *form* adds new ones; Smartsheet’s own alerts handle reminders and the weekly digest; Outlook Rules organize the email. Anything that must *update an existing row by key automatically from a pipeline* is the coded SAS/R version.

Make the tracker update itself — Smartsheet Automation, zero other tools

The single highest-value automation, entirely inside Smartsheet: the tracker **asks its owners for updates on a schedule**, so it's current every Monday without anyone opening it. (You need to be a licensed user with Owner or Admin permission on the sheet to build workflows.)



The finished workflow in Smartsheet's visual builder: one **WHEN** trigger (weekly, Monday) into one **THEN** action (Request an update → the row owner, four columns), then **Save**. The steps below build exactly this.

A — the recurring “Request an update” (keeps the tracker alive)

Fastest path: Smartsheet ships this as a template. **Automation** → **Create a workflow from a template** → **Popular Templates** → “Request an update every week” → **Use template**, then set the recipient and columns. Or build it yourself:

1. Open the sheet → **Automation** → **Create a workflow** → start from blank.
2. **Trigger: When a date is reached** → change *Run once* to **Custom** → in **Custom Recurrence** choose *Week*, Mondays, with a start date (and a trigger time).
3. **(Optional) Condition:** only rows where **Status** is not *Complete*, so finished work stops pestering people.
4. **Action: Request an update** → send to the row's **Assigned To** contact (the standard Smartsheet Contact column) → include *only* the columns they own (**Status** , **% Complete** , **Next action** , **Due**).
5. **Save**. Each Monday every open row's owner gets an email; they click **Open request**, fill just their cells, and **Submit** — it writes straight back to that row.

Two things that make this great: recipients **don't need a Smartsheet login** (any email address works), and because they edit the *existing* row, it's always in place — **never a duplicate**. **One caveat to tell people:** they must click *Open request* and *Submit* — simply *replying* to the email does not save the update.

B — alert on a slip (configure once)

1. **Automation** → **Create a workflow** → **Trigger: When rows are changed**, watching the **Status** column.
2. **Condition:** **Status** is **At Risk**.
3. **Action: Alert someone** → the **PM** (and the row owner) — message: “*{{Task}}* is now *At Risk*, due *{{Due}}*.”
(You can also **Alert a Microsoft Teams channel**.)

C — reminders before a due date

Automation → **Trigger: When a date is reached** → **Due**, *3 days before* → **Action: Alert someone** (the owner).
Smartsheet watches the calendar; you do nothing else.

Recipients, channels, and escalation live in the workflow — a PM edits them anytime, no code. Message bodies carry operational signal only (“DB lock At Risk, due 20 Jun”) — never anything participant-level.

Collect new items with a Smartsheet form

When people who don't live in Smartsheet need to send in new items — CRAs, vendors, data management — give them a **native Smartsheet form**. Each submission becomes a new row, straight into the sheet, with no other tool. (Forms *add* rows; to keep existing rows current, use the recurring [Request an update](#).)

1. In the sheet → **Forms** → **Create form**. Smartsheet builds a form from your columns.
2. Keep only operational fields (**Task** , **Status** , **% Complete** , **Note** , **Assigned To**); arrange and label them, then **publish** and share the link (or embed it on a page).
3. Every submission **adds a new row** — and that new row can itself trigger an *Alert someone* workflow (“new request logged → notify the PM”).
4. Optionally require fields or show a confirmation message — all in the form builder, no code.

Why a form, not an email-to-row bridge? A form gives you clean, structured rows every time — no parsing and no Power Automate. For keeping *existing* rows fresh, the recurring update request does it; for organizing the study email itself, use [Outlook Rules](#).

Organize the email & send the digest — all native

Organize study email with Outlook Rules

Use Outlook's own automation — Outlook's own Rules Wizard — so study-ops mail organizes itself. No Power Automate:

1. In Outlook: **Rules** → **Manage Rules & Alerts** → **New Rule** (the Rules Wizard).
2. **Condition:** *with specific words in the subject* = **CP-101** (or *from* the CRO distribution list).
3. **Action:** *move it to a* **CP-101** folder and *assign a category*; click **Finish**.
4. Now study mail is filed and tagged automatically — the team works from a clean folder and updates the tracker through the recurring [Request an update](#) or the [form](#).

Outlook Rules organize the *email*; Smartsheet keeps the *tracker* current. Keeping them separate is what lets the whole thing stay no-code — auto-turning an email's contents into a tracker row would need code/the API (the SAS/R SHEETLINK), and isn't needed here.

The weekly digest — inside Smartsheet

No external scheduler — Smartsheet sends it:

1. **Easiest:** build a **Report** filtered to **Status** = At Risk or **Due** overdue, then **Send it on a recurring schedule** (e.g., Friday 4 PM) to the team.
2. **Or:** an **Automation** — trigger **When a date is reached** (custom weekly recurrence) → **Alert someone**, with the matching at-risk & overdue rows in the message.
3. Either way it's one current summary every week, sent automatically by Smartsheet — no code, no Power Automate.

Governance, safety & honest limits

The data boundary (the reason this is safe to automate)

- **Operational columns only.** Milestone dates, deliverable/QC status, % Complete, aggregate counts, ownership. **Never** a participant-level value, anything unblinded or PHI, or a reported clinical number. The tracker is an operational convenience, not a clinical record.
- **Smartsheet is a tracker, not a system of record.** The validated outputs (SAS/R, Phoenix WinNonlin, the EDC/CTMS) remain the source of truth; the sheet mirrors *operational* status.
- **No AI and no bridge tool.** Everything is point-and-click in Smartsheet and Outlook; nothing parses your email into the sheet, so there's nothing to mis-read or mis-route.

Set-up safety (no code, but still real systems)

- **Workflows are owned by a licensed user.** Building Smartsheet Automation needs Owner or Admin permission on the sheet; keep that with the PM (and a named backup) so it doesn't break when someone leaves.
- **Share the sheet to the right people only.** Update requests can reach any email address you choose, but editing the sheet itself stays restricted to the team.
- **Test on a copy first.** Build the workflow on a sandbox copy of the sheet, confirm it behaves, then turn it on for the live tracker.
- **Recipients live in the workflow.** Keep who-gets-told in Smartsheet's Automation, where a PM can edit it — no code anywhere.

The honest limit

This keeps a tracker current and fires pre-configured alerts — it does not triage, narrate, or decide.

Smartsheet collects truthful operational updates from owners and forms and sends the alerts & digest; Outlook Rules organize the email; the PM and team own every decision. And the one thing these native tools deliberately can't do — update an existing row by key from a pipeline — is exactly what the coded SAS/R SHEETLINK is for.

FAQ

Do we need Power Automate? No — we deliberately don't use it. Smartsheet's own Automation keeps rows current and sends the alerts, reminders, and weekly digest; native **Smartsheet Forms** collect new items; **Outlook Rules** organize the email. All point-and-click, in tools you already have.

Do we need to write any code? No. Everything here is built in Smartsheet's Automation/Forms and Outlook's Rules — no scripts. This is the no-programming sibling of the SAS/R-driven version (which lives in the Biostatistician package).

Will it create duplicate rows? No — the recurring **Request an update** edits the *existing* row in place. A **form** adds a genuinely new row per submission, so use it for new items, not to refresh existing ones.

Do recipients need a Smartsheet license to respond? No. An update request works for any email address — they click *Open request*, fill their cells, and *Submit*. (A plain email reply does *not* write back.)

What about getting an email's contents into a row automatically? That's the one thing that needs code/the API (the SAS/R SHEETLINK). For the team, organize the mail with **Outlook Rules** and keep rows current with the **Request an update** — no bridge tool needed.

Do we have to buy anything? Smartsheet Automation and Forms are included with Smartsheet (building workflows needs a licensed user with Owner/Admin on the sheet). Outlook Rules are included with Outlook. Nothing else.

Could this leak PHI? Only if someone puts PHI on the sheet — so don't. Keep the columns operational; the tracker is a convenience mirror, not a clinical record.

How is this different from the SAS/R "SHEETLINK"? Same goal — a self-current tracker — with **no programming**, so the rest of the study team can own it. The SAS/R version does the one thing this can't: *update existing rows by key* automatically from a validated pipeline.